

Chapter 87-1 - Secret (Part 1)

"If Chu Qingqiu is truly from the spirit clan¹, then..." Ning Fuyi suddenly grabbed Jiang Li's sleeve, her eyes lighting up again. "Is there any possibility she could come back to life?"

She used too much force this time, pulling Jiang Li so hard that she bent over. Jiang Li struggled to pull back her sleeve: "I don't know about this either. As a member of the spirit clan, some can indeed regenerate from broken branches or divided bodies, but there has never been anyone who came back from the dead."

As soon as these words were spoken, the light in Ning Fuyi's eyes visibly dimmed, and she slumped down beside the table in defeat.

Seeing her lower her head with reddened eyes, Jiang Li couldn't bear it and steeled herself to add: "But, but I remember the Divine Venerable once told me that she wouldn't die so easily. Now that her corpse has completely disappeared, leaving only a seed, perhaps this seed really is her thread of hope?"

"Medical Immortal isn't just taking pity on me and deceiving me, are you?" Ning Fuyi smiled weakly.

"I'm not deceiving you, but making a reasonable guess. Someone as powerful as the Divine Venerable wouldn't perish so easily." Jiang Li said gently. "Although resurrection is absurd, it's not entirely impossible. Let me take another look."

She pulled over the deep-sea glazed cup and examined it carefully, then condensed dew from her fingertips and sprinkled it on the small sprout.

However, the sprout seemed completely indifferent to the water, even twisting its tender shoot to avoid the water drops.

"It's useless. It doesn't drink ordinary water. It looks down on any immortal dew or sweet rain - it only drinks this." Ning Fuyi blinked and squeezed a tear from the corner of her eye, then lightly swept her finger.

The tear flew through the air and fell into the soil. Faint white light particles rose from the soil and all fell into the center of the tender sprout.

The small sprout instantly forgot its earlier anger and swayed happily left and right.

"Amazing, too amazing." Jiang Li tapped her chin with her fingertip. What she was seeing temporarily exceeded her lifetime of learning, forcing her to consider carefully.

"The sprout is too small, its spiritual intelligence hasn't opened, so we can't fully explore its power yet. For now, we can only first grow this gardenia flower and wait for it to mature before making plans. Perhaps the Divine Venerable's physical body was transformed from the gardenia flower, and when it blooms, the Divine Venerable will return."

"It's just that if it only feeds on tears, then Young Sect Leader will have quite a lot to keep busy with," Jiang Li sighed. "But the possibility that the Divine Venerable might come back from the dead gives Young Sect Leader more hope."

"What do I hope for from her? I'm just troubled and can't let go. I have some things I want to ask her face to face." Ning Fuyi flicked her finger toward the small sprout, but softened the force halfway, painlessly brushing off the water on it.

Jiang Li looked away as if seeing through everything, touching her nose tip.

Seeing that she couldn't get any more answers, Ning Fuyi carefully put the small sprout back into the thought bead and rose to leave.

"Where is Young Sect Leader going?" Jiang Li also got up with her, worried. "Why not stay at the Jiang family for a day or two first, and leave after your injuries heal? Now that all four realms are hunting you, where can you go once you leave the Jiang family's gates?"

"The vast world will always have a place to shelter. I still have things to do and will take care of myself. Thank you, Medical Immortal Jiang, for being willing to clear up my doubts." Ning Fuyi said while arranging her skirt hem.

Hearing this, Jiang Li could only nod, then seemed to remember something. She turned to search around the room, threw a pile of rare pills into a medicine box, and stuffed it all along with gold and silver into Ning Fuyi's arms.

"Since the Divine Venerable trusted me so much, I should also properly look after you for her. It's just that I'm currently not free to leave the Jiang family and can't leave with you." Jiang Li raised her rippling eyes. "I only hope Young Sect Leader can take care of herself in the future. When I one day regain my freedom, I will definitely come help you."

Ning Fuyi held the huge medicine box in her hands, her fingertips trembling momentarily before finally putting it away, her expression grateful.

"Knowing I'm a demon creature in people's mouths, yet still willing to help with all your might." Her red lips parted. "Thank you."

"Come now, since we've met, why keep thanking me repeatedly?" Jiang Li smiled. "On this parting, I only hope we can meet again in jianghu² someday."

"I hope so too." Ning Fuyi smiled.

Just then, Jiuying's urgent voice suddenly rang in her mind: "Ning Fuyi! I saw a group of immortal soldiers heading toward Wushan. I'm afraid they're almost at the Jiang family now. You need to leave quickly!"

Hearing this, Ning Fuyi's spirit jolted. She immediately put on the divine artifact to conceal her appearance and prepared to flash out: "Penglai's people have caught up."

"How does Penglai know you're here? Could it be that grandmother sensed something wrong and notified Penglai!" Jiang Li grabbed Ning Fuyi. "Don't go through the front door, go through the back."

She pulled Ning Fuyi through the window, but suddenly a dark stream of light flashed before them. Ning Fuyi quickly pushed Jiang Li aside and raised the Emei Thorns to meet the light. Then came a loud clang as the two magical artifacts collided, the sound echoing throughout the entire estate.

Ning Fuyi stepped back several paces, hiding her numbed right hand in her sleeve, coldly looking at the newcomer.

That person wore silver robes, a huge hood drooping over their eyes, concealing their features completely. Cold qi surrounded them like an unfeeling, heartless blade that created endless slaughter.

It was the Black Scales³ who had captured her along with Lord Wen Yao at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate that day. Ning Fuyi remembered Jiuying saying this person's cultivation was unfathomably deep, so she gripped the Emei Thorns tightly, not daring to be careless.

"Who are you to dare intrude on my Jiang family estate like this!" Jiang Li shouted sternly, but that person seemed not to hear, eyes fixed only on Ning Fuyi as they swung their palm artifact at her again.

Black mist shrouded an ancient silver dagger. There were no elaborate immortal techniques, just strike after deadly strike. After blocking one attack, the next was already coming at her face. Ning Fuyi was exhausted from defending and couldn't spare any attention.

Soon, the ancient silver dagger was only half an inch from slicing across her throat. Ning Fuyi broke out in cold sweat all over. Just then, Jiang Li suddenly threw something at the two of them. Acrid white smoke immediately enveloped them both. Ning Fuyi quickly closed her eyes, seized the opportunity, and silently recited an incantation to summon heavenly thunder while viciously hurling the Emei Thorns.

Fortunately, the poison smoke hindered that person's movements, and the heavenly thunder drew their attention, so the Emei Thorns found an opening and nearly pierced that person's face.

However, that person was extremely agile, bending their body like a snake to barely dodge the Emei Thorns. At the same time, their hood slipped off, revealing seaweed-like curly hair that covered their face and was blown about by the wind.

Under the dark hair, eyebrows and eyes were revealed. Those features showed no surprise, only indifference, as if fighting was ordinary and injury was nothing special.

It was actually a strikingly beautiful woman with long, limber limbs. She crouched and spun in place to dodge Ning Fuyi's Emei Thorns.

When she straightened up, her slender, well-defined hands gathered her long hair and used the dagger to pin it up. That head of black, lustrous hair couldn't be cut by the blade.

Jiang Li suddenly covered her lips, her beautiful eyes widening as she stood frozen in place.

"Little Black..." she murmured.

Seeing the beautiful woman's flowing light already turning toward Jiang Li, Ning Fuyi quickly created a barrier to block this strike for her, pulling her behind herself: "Jiang Li!"

"Young Sect Leader!" Jiang Li quickly regained her composure and pushed Ning Fuyi toward the back mountain: "You're severely injured and no match for her. While the other immortal soldiers haven't arrived yet, go quickly. Follow the agate-paved path to the back mountain. I have a way to hold this person off!"

Ning Fuyi wanted to say something more, but Jiang Li swung her veil and threw her over the courtyard wall: "Go quickly!"

Ning Fuyi didn't dare delay any longer. After one last look at Jiang Li, she turned in mid-air and rode the Emei Thorns away, her figure quickly disappearing.

Seeing this, Black Scales started to give chase, but Jiang Li gritted her teeth and threw out a jar of realgar powder⁴. The yellow powder scattered in the wind immediately enveloped her. Black Scales seemed instinctively afraid of realgar powder and quickly picked up the hood to cover her head and face.

Then she flipped her palm to summon fierce wind, blowing away the realgar powder all over the sky before coldly throwing off the hood and looking at Jiang Li standing dazed in place with murderous intent.

"You didn't die..." Jiang Li bit the flesh of her lips, unable to believe her eyes. She reached out to touch the beautiful woman but was dodged.

"If you interfere again, I'll kill you too." The beautiful woman's voice was harsh and ethereal as she turned into black smoke to chase Ning Fuyi.

"Little Black Snake, Little Black Snake!" Jiang Li leaped over the courtyard wall with tears, but that person's figure had long since disappeared.

On the other end, Ning Fuyi had already returned to Baili Shiqi's carriage. The three of them hurried out of Wushan's territory, rushing toward a more distant direction.

Jiuying grabbed Ning Fuyi's hands and examined her up and down: "That really scared me just now - so many immortal soldiers in a mass. Fortunately, you had us wait outside the estate, otherwise we who just escaped would be captured again!"

Ning Fuyi brushed away her red-nailed claws and shook her head: "Fortunately Medical Immortal Jiang helped, but I had already used magical artifacts to hide my appearance and qi. I don't know how that person called Black Scales still discovered my whereabouts."

"This divine beast is also puzzled." Jiuying raised her beautiful leg and toyed with a strand of hair in her hand. "Even I couldn't smell yours and the Divine Venerable's qi at the time. How could a small Penglai person manage it?"

Baili Shiqi, who was counting magical artifacts nearby, finally interjected quietly: "Perhaps Shiqi's magical artifacts aren't as good as the Divine Venerable's. The Divine Venerable surely used divine artifacts."

"Perhaps that's so." Ning Fuyi said, taking out the cool jade pendant from the thought bead and examining it in her palm.

"This is what the Divine Venerable left for you?" Jiuying reached out to touch it but was dodged by Ning Fuyi turning away. Her hand awkwardly circled around to touch her hair instead. "There's nothing on this - what could it tell you?"

Ning Fuyi couldn't figure it out either. She turned the jade pendant several times. The pendant was milky white and smooth. She recited several revelation spells at it, but the pendant remained motionless.

"No concealment, no immortal power - just a fragment that fell from the white bone." Ning Fuyi gently caressed it with her fingertip. "I'm thinking, could this be a token to open something?"

"Jingshan Palace⁵?" Jiuying clicked her tongue. "No, that's not right. Jingshan Palace has already turned to ruins. All that's left there is the masterless white bone."

Ning Fuyi shook her head, then suddenly had a flash of inspiration and slapped her palm on the carriage.

"Shiqi." Her voice was unsteady. "We're going to Purple Mist Peak⁶!"

With Jiang Li's pills, Ning Fuyi and Jiuying's internal injuries recovered much faster, and they could now travel by sword. So the time to reach Purple Mist Peak was greatly shortened. In just three short days, they were already standing at the foot of the mountain.

Ning Fuyi wore a black cloak, looking up from under her hood at the peak where clouds rolled, momentarily dazed.

The last time she came was just after her rebirth. In a flash, the mountains and rivers had entered deep autumn.

Less than a year had passed, yet it felt like much more than a moment - enough to match the vicissitudes of time.

Footnotes:

1. **Spirit clan (精灵族):** A fairy-like race in this cultivation world, typically considered the weakest of the six realms
2. **Jianghu (江湖):** The martial arts/cultivation world community
3. **Black Scales (黑鳞):** An elite warrior from Penglai, characterized by black scale-like armor
4. **Realgar powder (雄黄粉):** A traditional Chinese mineral powder believed to repel evil spirits and certain demons
5. **Jingshan Palace (静山宫):** "Tranquil Mountain Palace" - Chu Qingqiu's former residence
6. **Purple Mist Peak (紫霞峰):** The mountain peak where Chu Qingqiu lived and where Ning Fuyi's mother Ning Changfeng once stayed